THE ROYAL BRITISH LEGION

PARIS BRANCH

SPECIAL MINI NEWSLETTER AUGUST 2015

Chairman's Report

"Something is rotten in the state of Denmark". Sad to relate that our relationship with RBL London Head Office is going through a turbulent period. Those of you who have worked in large organizations will be very familiar with the usual periodic tensions between subsidiaries and their remote Head Office. The cause of these tensions is usually poor change management, backed by Diktats from the centre which seem insensitive to life on the ground at the level of the subsidiary.

Well that is exactly what is currently happening between RBL Branches and London Head Office. Not just Overseas branches but those in the U.K. too. So what is the root of this malaise? In November 2014 your officers received a delegation from London who alerted us to a National Council decision to have all members' 2015-16 subscriptions paid direct to an RBL London bank account. Your Officers and Committee quickly sensed that this was a done deal, with the decision already taken over our heads. Added to which come the usual banking/accounting problems inherent in such a payment system. That turned out to be the case, because, apart from the technical complications of the new arrangements, on close examination your Officers and Committee detected that any payment by an overseas branch like ours to a Head Office in another jurisdiction would not qualify the member to the tax rebate, which in France is usual when backing a charitable organization "d'intérêt public". The Council Diktat was that NO subscription funds may pass via the Branch Bank accounts; The payments shall be in euros into a new Euro RBL London bank account? Does the individual member pick up any transfer/bank charges in such payments ? And so on.

Your Committee spotted all these complications, and I was mandated to express our misgivings at the highest level in London. The email was addressed to the National President, Rear-Admiral Sir Peter Wilkinson, and to the National Chairman, John Crisford (Copy attached 'Sir Peter"). We pleaded for exemption from the system for overseas branches. Acknowledgement of its receipt was sent to me, but never any comments or official reaction. Then came the bombshell when members like you recently received a letter direct from RBL London, outlining the new procedure, but not inviting any comment from the grassroots. The rest is history: Quite spontaneously a few members contacted either RBL London or one of your Paris Branch officers expressing surprise and sometimes shock at the tax implications of the new system for members living in France who have traditionally been able to acquire a tax rebate on the subscription fee. This letter was sent out without your Branch Officers' knowledge, and therefore before your Branch had had time to brief members on what to expect. Some of our officers have subsequently been obliged to reply on the background to these talks with those members. It was an exasperating piece of news for your Officers and Committee. We felt and still feel that the system was half-baked by not taking into account from the beginning the reality on the ground.

Many are planning or threatening to resign as a direct result of the new system. This your Committee had foreseen from the beginning. We have expressed our renewed

express concern in my email to John Crisford, National Chairman of 15th July which is also attached. No comment received from London.

If the Subscription saga was hard enough for your Branch officers and Committee to swallow this was only compounded by a decision against us in a quite different register. In the early Spring we were invited by Rod Bedford, the Overseas Branches' Representative on the National Council, to consider taking over the responsibility of the territory previously covered by the now disbanded Normandy Calvados Branch. The possibility of subsequently hiving off that Normandy area with a view to those creating their own independent Branch was also discussed. We said we were honoured to be considered and the Officers put in a lot of thought in preparing our due diligence questions for Rod to answer before any commitment or EGM on our side. Those questions are contained in the document attached ("Questions and Answers"), along with the very inadequate and often unconvincing answers. Then the file seems to have been ignored by Rod. In the meantime your Branch was represented at the 6th June traditional ceremony at Bayeux Cathedral. After the ceremony, as reported in the last Newsletter, we laid a wreath in Bayeux Military Cemetery, along with two new French partner associations operating in the Normandy area, Association Overlord, and the Association 51st Highland Division Spirit. We have formed a good relationship with both. But then came a bombshell in the form of an email from Rod Bedford dated 9th July 2015 (Copy attached to the email to John Crisford above) couched in very cavalier terms saying that the decision had been taken to have a new stand-alone Normandy Branch. It then took our breath away when the text went on to seek our approval to have London approach existing Paris Branch members living in Normandy to invite them to consider joining the new Branch. This is usually called "poaching" members I would have thought. We had planned that this proposal be the subject of a Paris Branch EGM in the Autumn.

In the event the stand-alone decision appears not to have been taken by National Council in London, but unilaterally by Rod Bedford.

These two episodes/files form the background to the mood here in Paris, among your Branch Officers and Committee, of being steam-rollered by the London Diktat, with, in the case of the Subs issue, no prior consultation at the planning stage. And in the case of the Normandy file, we were consulted but the replies to our questions were worse than useless in a professional takeover context.

The Officers and Committee believe that we are a Branch very committed to the RBL cause, with a strong Poppy Appeal and Welfare record, backed by sound financial housekeeping. We must seek to re-build bridges with London, and we have therefore invited the National Chairman to address us and to answer our questions on the hoof. This occasion will be the Annual Committee Dinner on the eve of our 4th August ceremony. The National Chairman will be accompanied by Rod Bedford. We shall report on the speeches and discussions at this dinner in our next Newsletter, most probably in September.

"We will remember them"

Roger Thorn
Chairman

Message du 12/02/15 17:29
De : "Roger THORN" <roger.thorn@wanadoo.fr
A : aforder@britishlegion.org.uk
Copie à : jcrisford@britishlegion.org.uk, rbedford@britishlegion.org.uk
Objet : e-mail to National President

Dear Andrea,

I should be grateful if you could bring my letter below to the attention of Sir Peter Wilkinson. As you will see it is copied to the National Chairman and to Rod Bedford.

With many thanks.

Roger Thorn

Téléphone: 01.34.80.13.33
Portable: 06.22.09.41.32

For the Attention of Sir Peter Wilkinson

Dear Sir Peter,

Comradeship Project

In November the Officers of the Paris Branch of The Royal British Legion hosted a meeting in Paris with representatives from Head Office (Overseas Support and the Comradeship Project team). The meeting was also attended by senior representatives of other branches in France. The purpose of the meeting was to receive a presentation of the Comradeship Project (called "Project" below) and to allow us to raise our questions on the proposal. This presentation was made very professionally. A number of issues were raised on which we are still waiting for a ruling.

I write this e-mail to you following a resolution at the Paris Branch Committee meeting in January at which I was mandated to register our very serious misgivings of the impact of the Project on the membership and income of our Branch. We fully recognize that the thrust of the Project is to make more efficient the collection of subscriptions and to create a central, modernised data base on RBL membership. While this is clearly logical in the U.K., in our view circumstances in overseas branches militate against any gain in efficiency locally. Indeed the opposite appears to us to be true, and doubtless these advantages will be apparent to other overseas branches/districts.

At the November meeting it became clear to us that the decision to set up the Project had already been taken. On this point we are alarmed that there was no prior consultation with overseas branches, since it cannot simply be assumed that the circumstances in which we operate should be regarded as the same as apply in the U.K.

seem to have been ignored/were not explored at the design stage.

Our specific points of concern may be summarized as follows:

- We have a very real issue with non-English speaking members and with the fact that many overseas members have a great feeling of loyalty towards the local, country set-up rather than a remote overseas head office. It is therefore apparent to us that a number of the older members could well resign from the RBL because it would be perceived that it no longer represents them at local level. Here in France there will be resistance particularly among our French members to the thought of sending a French euro cheque abroad. It is also inconceivable that a French member would consider making a direct debit payment to London, with the accompanying bank charges. Furthermore communication with London would not be effective for many of our French members whose command of the English language is inadequate. Any attempt for us to use the argument that the Project is in the interests of administrative efficiency would be lost on them. Since we have a high percentage of French members we estimate conservatively that perhaps as many as 10% of our Paris Branch members would not renew their subscription. Indeed we have heard the view that some of the smaller branches in France could be obliged to close as a result of this drop-off in membership. These branches cover areas of France where a number of British expatriate ex-servicemen and women have settled, plus surviving family members who qualify for welfare support from the RBL, and so there would be a loss of visibility, of critical welfare provision and of an organized presence for the important local ceremonies.

- In France subscriptions and donations made to a charitable association confer the right to deduct these amounts in personal income tax declarations. The Project provides for the subscriptions to be banked in the U.K., and clearly those paying income tax in France will lose this tax advantage.

- Many overseas branches which cover a large geographical area take the opportunity when sending out their Subscription renewal notices of making it one single hit to invite members to make donations at the same time to both their branch General Fund and the Poppy Appeal Fund. This source of donation revenues represents a significant percentage of total donation income into both Funds. We risk to lose this source, in part or whole, or else the branch would have to rely on a second hit, which would certainly not enjoy the same success rate. For small branches donation income is extremely important. As an example, in 2014 12% of Poppy Appeal income and 55% of General Fund donations to Paris Branch were generated from the cheques sent in to pay subscription renewals We do not feel the imposition of the Project would automatically lead to a freeing-up of branch officers during Remembrancetide. In our experience the Poppy Organizer takes full charge of the campaign.

- Officers of overseas branches will be hard put to it to reconcile keeping things as simple as possible for existing and new members on the one hand, with

ensuring that the branch gets full benefit from the aims of the project and that the income for the branch isn't further impacted by bank charges, currency risk and timing delays.

We recommend for your attention that any move to set up the Project overseas should therefore be put on hold until a full review has been conducted of its feasibility. While recognizing the obvious merits of the Project in the U.K. context, our clear preference would be to see overseas branches exempted from the Project altogether, given the particular circumstances which prevail. We would be pleased to organize a meeting with our fellow branches in France to discuss these issues in front of a senior delegation from London. Here in Paris we are highly motivated RBL members, and we would not like to be regarded as Luddites, but being purely pragmatic the Project brings no evident advantages to the overseas branches, quite the opposite in fact.

Yours sincerely,

Roger Thorn

Chairman

Paris Branch

The Royal British Legion

QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS AS PUT TO ROD BEDFORD

1. Legal/Administrative

Q. Could we continue to be called Paris Branch or would Council insist on the inclusion of the word Normandy? We have in mind here the cost of two new standards, not to mention the necessary changes to our statutes.

Answer

No. You would become the Paris Normandy Branch.

Q. Can we assume that the old Normandy Calvados Branch has been wound up and that there remain neither bank accounts, funds nor paid-up members? Has the relevant Prefecture been informed of the closure?

Answer

Yes all is wound up and all have been informed, and all bank accounts closed.

Q. Are you aware of any outstanding debts of the old Branch, including outside creditors -bars, restaurants?

Answer

There are no outstanding debts or creditors

Q. Are you aware of any 'unfinished business' with for example, local authorities?

Answer

As before, all have been informed.

Q. Is there any surviving archive material which could be released to us for examination? Minutes, correspondance with outside contacts etc?

Answer

There are no surviving archive material

Q. Could our Treasurer have sight of the historical bank statements for, say, the final 24 months of the old branch?

Answer

No the accounts are closed, those available were audited and of no concern to the new branch, as they would not effect the way future business will be managed.

2. Geographical

Q. Could you confirm please that the area in question comprises the French Province of 'Normandy' which is made up of the two Regions, Haute Normandie and Basse Normandie? It is our understanding that the area to the west of this, the Brest peninsular, remains the preserve of the Brittany Branch,but that we inherit the PA responsibilities in Normandy until now covered by Brittany Branch?

Answer

Yes you will have full responsibility entirely for Normandy in all aspects, Brest is the

responsibility of Brittany.

Q. Incidentally Paris Branch had already taken over the Rouen PA area when the local Branch closed some time ago.

Answer

Rouen will revert to the responsibility of Normandy, (can you advise if the PA in Rouen was a local branch initiative or authorised through the PA or MC)

3. Ceremonial

Q. Could you list for us please the ceremonies previously covered by the Normandy-Calvados Branch together with their dates.

Answer

At the moment it will be 6th June Bayeux Cathedral and Cemetery events with representation at the many to which TRBL are invited, too numerous to list at present. Brittany attend a service at Ranville, just as the Paris branch has arranged the adopt a grave initiative which I will cover in another email.

Q. Concerning the Bayeux events on 6th June in the Cathedral and the CWGC Cemetery, we judge that we would not be in a position to be responsible for their organization this year given the fact that they take place only one month after any EGM of ours. But if our EGM adopts any resolution to annex the area then we should want and need to be active observers, and participants this year working closely with London and the Embassy so that we would be competent to take over the reins in Bayeux in 2016. Given our proven success in organizing the Service in Notre Dame on 11/11 we feel confident in our ability to transfer those skills to Bayeux next year.

Answer

The new Normandy will not take effect till all 2015 accounts are closed, you are advised to attend 2015 to understand the ask in Normandy, it is very much more than the excellnt Notre Dame Service

Q. Are you aware of the existence of any standards?

Answer

The old standard was never recovered, if you are aware of it location I would be pleased to know as legal action will be taken to recover it.

Q. We shall of course need to train some new standard-bearers to cover any other ceremonies in Normandy.

Answer

It would be One Standard 'Paris Normandy Branch', a branch may only Parade ONE standard, the number of SB is the choice of the branch.

4. Membership

We have 8 Paris Branch members who live in Normandy. You say you have a list of former Normandy Calvados branch members. May we please have a copy of the list of all know RBL members in this region, together with their postal and email addresses. In this way when the time comes we shall be able to write to them to inform them of the new structure, and invite them to be a part of it. In your experience would they be likely to accept being members of a new structure? Are they mainly resident in the UK? Would they be likely to take an active part in our activities : PA, Welfare? Or are they mainly interested only in the Bayeux ceremonies? Would they help us to attract new members? Without a list of

former members of the old branch and of all existing RBL members whose address is in the region our view is that our attempt to relaunch the branch would be severely hampered. Incidentally we would be very interested in attracting French members, as we do in Paris.

Answer

No list will be forwarded, any existing members will be written to inviting them to join the new branch or transfer to a branch of their choice (as per policy).

5. Welfare

Are there any welfare cases still current dating from the days of the former branch?

Answer

Not aware of any outstanding.

6. Poppy Appeal

Are there any Poppy boxes still physically in Normandy? If so who holds them please? Perhaps Brittany Branch hold some too? Do lists exist of the locations where Poppy boxes used to be left during Remmbrancetide? If so may we have them please?

Answer

All PA at present is undertaken by Brittany but all would be handed over.

Dear John,

Loyal greetings from Paris Branch.

Since our telephone conversation the other day on the subject of the "Normandy branch" I have received the email below from Rod Bedford. Its contents I have shared with the Paris Branch officers, who are as shocked as I am by the cavalier attitude which it adopts.
It does not specify who has taken the decision that Normandy be a stand alone unit. Only the other day on the phone I recall you visualized the possibility of creating a sub-branch of the Paris Branch, with the later option of changing into an independent Branch in the future when the time was judged right.

So may we enquire whether the decision referred to by Rod was taken by the National Council, or whether it was taken unilaterally please ? If the announcement was made for tactical reasons it may be London's attempt to stuff the genie back in the bottle ?

A National Council decision we would be obliged to respect naturally. But either way we feel shabbily treated. When offered the opportunity of taking over full responsibility for the "Normandy Branch" area we took the offer very seriously, spending a lot of valuable time submitting to Rod a list of very targeted due diligence questions to which any acquirer in a commercial situation would need the answers. I attach our original list of questions with the very inadequate answers which we received. From this our officers concluded that we did not have sufficient information to brief our Committee adequately, let alone if we were to call an inevitable EGM.

To then announce that a decision had been taken that there should be a stand alone unit seems to us to be a quantum, uninformed jump in position. Added to that, salt was rubbed into the wound by the suggestion that we allow our Paris Branch members living in the Normandy area to be seduced into joining a new, untried Normandy Branch. Our older members have long, but still fresh memories of the mismanagement of the old Normandy Calvados Branch.

Following on from the bombshell the other day when certain of our members received a letter from Head Office announcing the new Subscription payment system, BEFORE the officers had been alerted, so that we now need to pick up the pieces of this P.R. disaster, and you will I think begin to understand our frustration as the Branch officers. From the outset we identified the shortcomings of the Comradeship scheme when applied to overseas branches. It was no coincidence that the first two ripostes to the London letter came from two Paris members who are retired Chartered Accountants/Finance Directors, who pointed out that under the scheme members in France would no longer be able to benefit from a tax rebate on their subs and donations, since they would be paying in the UK. Plus our French members risk resigning their membership when asked in English by London to pay direct to London. Our conservative estimate is that there would be a loss of at least 10% of our membership following the introduction of the Comradeship project. Then to be asked if further members could be lost by poaching just about takes the biscuit. I was obliged to make an impromptu apology at our Monthly Lunch this last

Thursday, explaining to members what the London letter implied. The clear fact remains that the Comradeship project took no account right from the beginning of the circumstances in which Overseas Branches operate. It was already a done deal. The Paris branch officers will need to work extra hard over the coming months to maintain morale.

Added to all this we were taking the Normandy offer seriously enough to get very involved with the two French veterans' associations operating in the Normandy area. I referred to this development in our July Branch Newsletter, which you will have received. Our new, very motivated partners will be very puzzled to be fobbed off onto an untried management team of a new Branch. The list of the likely fallout of both the Normandy branch file and the Comradeship file goes on. Our Vice-Chairman represented us at the Overseas Forum of the 2014 National Conference and had the feeling that there was little spontaneous debate on matters affecting us overseas members.

Please do not get the impression that we are bunch of grousers, or Luddites resisting change. You will be hard put to it to find a more motivated team of Branch officers. But here we feel we are boxing with our hands tied behind our backs. On our Committee we have a broad range of retired and active businessmen and bankers and members of other professions, experienced in working in large organizations and it is no exaggeration to say that my colleagues are horrified by the lack of consultation particularly with overseas branches.

We do hope you will be free to accept our Diner invitation on 3rd August before our 4th August ceremony. I firmly believe it is vital for you to get a feel of the grass-roots feelings which are now spilling over. Your very presence and an after-dinner speech from you will give the Branch officers additional motivation and authority in dealing with the fallout described above in this message. We understand Rod cannot be present, being committed elsewhere.

Kind regards

Roger Thorn

Chairman
Paris Branch
the Royal British Legion

Message du 09/07/15 16:15
De : RBedford@britishlegion.org.uk
A : roger.thorn@wanadoo.fr
Copie à :
Objet : RE: Paris Branch Ceremony and Committee Dinner

Dear Roger
Thank you for the kind invitation which I would have very much enjoyed, alas I'm already committed thus unable to attend.

With regard the formation of a Normandy branch, it is now decided that Normandy should be a stand alone branch, it undoubtably has the potential to be a flag ship branch for TRBL.

There are a number of RBL members living in Normandy who are members of the Paris, Brittany, Somme and various UK branches, would you have any objections if I were write to your branch members living in Normandy with the informations and invitations to be involved in a stand alone Normandy branch, either a member of both or the invitations to transfer to a new Normandy branch.

Rod
Rod Bedford
Membership Council Representative for overseas branches and districts.
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